

allow you to print stuff off the MFD without any intervention from the system. There are many apps supported by HP C310a but only a limited number of them are available in India, which should hopefully change with time.

Brother MFC-J615W

Black seems to be a favourite with MFD companies. Brother MFC-J615W also comes in a piano black glossy body, which is radically different from its traditional white / grey coloured devices that we have tested in the past. In terms of form factor, not much has changed from the DCP series of MFDs, but the two-line monochrome display is replaced by a 3.3-inch colour display.

USB and network connection ports are still under the hood of the MFD with a nice channel for the cords. This design was seen in older models and prevents accidental removal of cords. The power connector is of the BS-1363 type (commonly known as flatpin - typical to UAE and European regions) which will require a universal spike guard or an adapter, if your electrical sockets are not compatible.

MFC-J615W can print, copy, scan and also has the fax functionality. There are direct buttons to access these functions. The W in the nomenclature indicates Wi-Fi support. You can set up Wi-Fi on the MFD in a couple of easy steps in the Settings menu. Cartridges are housed in the right hand corner section. Unlike the ADF found on other MFDs that we tested, in J615W, the documents need to be fed at the base of the ADF and they come out from the top. It also has an SD card slot and a USB slot for direct printing off or scanning to these devices.

Performance

In MFD testing, the outputs all appear to be the same at first glance as you are basically printing the same test sheets. However, for quality scores, we really have to look deep into each print. Of course the time taken for each print job is duly noted, but that is just one part of the test.



HP OFFICEJET PRO 8500A PLUS

This is one of the most good looking MFDs that we have ever come across in our labs in a long time. The front and top piano black glossy finishes are neatly complemented by matte black finishes on the right and left hand sides. Another interesting aspect of this MFD is the almost modular arrangement of various parts. The operational panel is a full touchscreen rectangular glass surface which looks eerily similar to an elongated iPod. This MFD comes with four colour cartridges namely C,M,Y and K and two extra which

comprise of the C+M and Y+K combination. Installing the cartridges is quite

easy if you follow the animation on the operational panel touchscreen. The operational panel is a 4.3-inch resistive touchscreen. The touchscreen can be made to lie flat with along the front portion of the MFD or tilted at an angle. The animations explaining tasks are quite helpful.

Initial setup of the MFD took close to 30 mins, which may seem too long as compared to the other MFDs we tested, which were up and running in five minutes. Paper input tray is located at the base and this is covered by the output tray which can be lifted at 45 degrees to refill more papers.

The ADF section is quite sturdy with boldly designed tray which can extend to accommodate 50-100 pages at a time easily.

All in all, this is one MFD that will occupy a place of pride in your home or office. The thing we really liked about this MFD is the ability to do so many things apart from just print, copy and scanning. It supports ePrint which means, you can send the document you want to print on an email ID from anywhere and the printer will print from the cloud. We tried our hands at it but were disappointed as we kept getting 'Message not sent' errors. It has a Pictbridge connectivity and also the option to print directly from memory cards.

Apps support : Google Docs, Tabbloid, Sudoku, Quick Forms, Yahoo News, DreamWorks are just some of the apps it supports. The 8500A needs to be connected to the internet to access apps. Google Docs app was quite fascinating. We actually printed out a document saved on Google Docs from the printer itself. This just takes printing over the air to a completely new level.

As far as text document printing goes, all the MFDs fared well, with the HP 8500A, C310a and Brother MFC J615W doing particularly well. The other MFDs gave decent prints, but in some text portions, we did notice sharpness of the fonts being compromised.

Unless your document is being read under the microscope, you shouldn't feel the jitters.

In the mixed document printing, we noticed that Brother MFC-J615W did not fare as well as the others. It

scored least on all five areas that we compared for all the MFDs. The test print comprises a section with black background and yellow text, which gradually reduces in size. In laser prints,

the yellow text is legible even at the smallest font size, but not so in the inkjet printers. Canon MP287 fared quite well in this parameter. Epson 620F took the longest time to print this document.

In the fast document printing, most MFDs gave the five prints fast, with

Epson 960FWD being fastest at 25 seconds.

We noticed that the quality of prints from the Epson MFDs was not usable as the colours were washed out and text was not sharp at all. HP and Canon's economy prints were better

compared to the rest.

Photo printing test was done at the best quality settings. Canon and HP MFDs scored higher than the other MFDs. HP C310a gave the best photo



Brother MFC-J615W looks beautiful and occupies less space on your desk